

also provide pointing sticks as the pointing device. Go for one with which you are most comfortable.

Memory Card Reader

 If you own a digital camera or any other device that uses a memory card (such as SD, MMC, CF or Memory Stick), it makes sense to purchase a notebook that has an inbuilt memory card reader. This way, you can transfer data to and from the card without the need to buy a separate memory card reader. Check whether the card reader in the notebook is compatible with the type of memory card you use.

Ease Of Use

 Some notebooks feature scroll keys along with the touchpad keys to enable vertical and/or horizontal scrolling in large documents. Some also feature hotkeys for launching your favourite applications.

Additional Features

 Additional features, including integrated Bluetooth, biometric security, keyboard light and integrated Web cams, are offered in some models. Since these extra features also affect the pricing of the laptop, opt for one that has the features you need.

USING A LAPTOP

Shortcuts To Success

 Create shortcuts to your most commonly used applications, folders and files on the desktop. This way, you can access them quickly. If you like your desktop clutter-free, you can also create custom toolbars in Windows XP.

To do this, right click on the Windows taskbar, go to 'Toolbars' and click on 'New Toolbar'. Next, choose the drive or folder you want to access using the toolbar. You can create different toolbars for different drives and folders. To remove a toolbar you added, right click on the Windows taskbar, go to

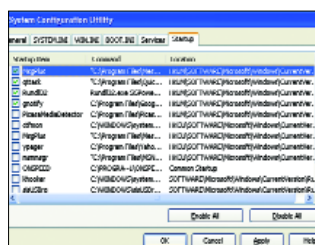


Toolbars in Windows XP

'Toolbars', and uncheck the toolbar. This is useful for sales executives who want easy access to presentations, proposals and other information on a day-to-day basis.

Boot Faster

 To make your notebook boot faster, remove unwanted programs from



Programs that run at startup

startup. To do this, go to **Start > Run**, type "msconfig" and press [Enter]. Go to the Startup tab and uncheck any programs you do not need. Click on 'OK' and then click on 'Exit' without restarting. The unchecked programs will not run the next time you boot.

Clean Up The Junk

 Uninstall any applications you do not use. Apart from saving on disk space, you will also prevent your notebook from slowing down.

Be Resourceful

 Keep backups of the operating system, drivers and commonly used applications on a secondary partition so that you can do some re-installing on your own if you face some issues while travelling. Carry driver CDs and recovery disks with you.

Prevention Is Better Than Cure

 Since a notebook may be connected to different networks, such as at a client's office, for example, it is essential you use a good anti-virus and firewall

software. Update your virus definitions frequently. An anti-spyware program is recommended.

LAPTOP SECURITY

Don't Be A Jerk

 Be careful while carrying the notebook. Do not subject it to any jerks and shocks. This will avoid damage to your hard drive and the precious data on it. Preferably, power the notebook off before moving it from one place to another.

Dusty Notebooks Don't Impress

 Protect your laptop from dust. Clean your laptop regularly to prevent dust accumulation. Do not leave your notebook on the floor and make sure all vents are clean to enable good air flow.

Drinks And Laptops Don't Mix

 Avoid having beverages while working on your laptop. Do not place any containers filled with hot or cold beverages near your notebook, to minimise chances of a spill.

Protect Your Laptop

 Do not leave your notebook unattended in a car or in a client's office. Be careful when going to a restaurant or when using public transport.

Backup, Backup, Backup!

 Keep backups of all your important files and e-mails in a safe location such as your desktop PC or an external drive. This way you

still have your precious data even in case your notebook is stolen.

Power Surges

 Use a surge protector with your laptop to protect it from power surges.

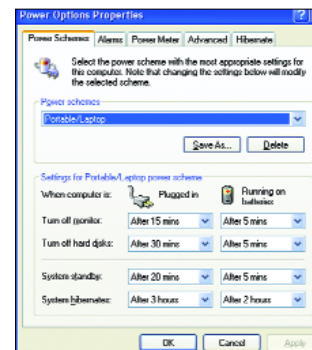
POWER-SAVING TIPS

Condition Your Battery

 A new battery needs to be conditioned—it must be fully charged and discharged a few times before it can use its full capacity.

Leave Power Management To The Pros

 Use the notebook's power management features to improve battery life. You can set the device to switch off the LCD screen and hard drive after set intervals of time.



Power options in Windows XP

Screen Scream

 The screen hogs a lot of battery power. To prolong battery life, dim the screen brightness when you are not connected to a power source.

Close Applications

 Close any applications you are not using when on battery power. Running applications increase CPU utilisation, thus reducing battery life.

Disconnect

 External peripherals and accessories such as external optical drives, PC cards and USB keyboard lights draw power from the notebook. Disconnect any such devices when not in use.